one more sleep

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/44356981.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), glimbow are there but in the background

Additional Tags:
Christmas Fluff, chanukah fluff as well, 5 Things, Inspired by Music, SPOP Flex Secret Solstice (She-Ra), SPOP Creative Flex (She-Ra), Chatting & Messaging

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one more sleep

by hopelessgemini

Summary

princess (dumbass) (affectionate) at 4:01 AM: Catra
Catra
Catra
Catra
Catra
Catra
Catra
Catra
I talked to my boss
She says I can come home for Christmas
I love you
I'll be there on the 25th
5 days
Like the Leona Lewis song
I'm so excited :D

catra: baby it's 4 am

or, the coming home for christmas fic where adora attempts to prepare romantic and spontaneous Schemes and Plans and catra is too busy being gay to have normal people thoughts. written for lotteez for the spop flex secret solstice!

Notes

happy late holdiays to everyone who celebrated! i tried my best to make this fic christmassy (it's based off that one leona lewis song in case. you know. it wasn't obvious) but naturally chanukah crept in there, so the backstory for this is that both catra and adora are jewish and kind of half-celebrate christmas in the 'decorating my house because winter' way

love wins ♥ i had a lot of fun writing this, even if it took fucking ages (exams. holidays. yeah), and i think (i hope) it shows? i did actually spend a lot of time editing it down and making the ending section slightly less upsettingly long but also everything i touch inevitably turns into a chatfic lmao

See the end of the work for more notes

Day 1 - December 21st, 4:05 AM

Catra wakes up to the sound of her phone buzzing so hard it falls off the table.

princess (affectionate) (dumbass) *at* ***4:01 AM***

Catra

Catra

Catra

Catra

Catra

Catra

Catra

Catra

I talked to my boss

She says I can come home for Christmas

I love you

I'll be there on the 25th

5 days

Like the Leona Lewis song

I'm so excited :D

baby it's 4 am

Timezones are a lie invented to sell more clocks

i love you too

more

go to sleep its like midnight for you

wait

FIVE DAYS???????

FIVE DAYS!!!!!!

LIKE THE LEONA LEWIS SONG

JESUS CHRIST

FIVE DAYS!!!!!!!!

i'm getting out all your moms chanukah stuff
and putting it all over the house

you won't be able to move for dreidels

chanukah was really sad without you :((

i miss you

I miss you too <33333

I can't wait to slip and break my neck on a dreidel!

I want cuddles so badddddd

Fiiive more days of sleeping on my ownnnn

that's too many days :(

well

less for me because you're a few hours behind

but still too many :(

Yeah :(

Just like the song though!

win

ok ok i'm going to bed

and so should you

i have the timezone widget i know it's midnight for you

>:(

Fine!

She rolls onto her back, smiling at the ceiling. Adora's presence — even from miles away — is soothing. It's soothing to know she's thinking about her, longing for the sound of her voice the same way Catra is. She misses her so much it hurts.

The other side of the bed is cold when she wakes up.

Catra leaves it empty on principle. It'd feel weird to take Adora's spot. Like filling in the gap she leaves behind. Even Melog, who mostly just naps and sits in his spot by the kitchen counter to scream for food, avoids the right side. Like he knows how Catra is feeling, and he's waiting for Adora too.

Part of her wonders if Adora will come back every time. That part is the one that needs therapy the most, she's decided.

Melog screaming for food is what gets her out of bed. She wakes up late — obviously — and lies there for a minute as he crawls all over her chest, staring at the ceiling.

4 more days. She can do 4 more days.

Day 2 - December 22nd, 2:41 PM

Adora wakes up late. Ridiculously late.

Catra <3 <3 <3 at 2:34 PM

how long are you going to be back for?

so can prepare yk

OOOH YES

I have good news :)

But it can wait until the 25th

wtf

nooooo

don't do this to me

babe

DW it's about something else hehe

I have to be back in Eternia on the 14th!

So we have ages :D

who did you have to kill to get that much time off??

Don't worry about it

;)

adora

adoraaaa

Adora smiles at her phone. She misses Catra so much it hurts. The bed she has is just large enough for her to feel the absence of another person. She never really gets used to sleeping on her own.

She gets up slowly and crosses the room in a daze, trusting the light of the phone screen to let her see just enough to make it to

the door. She wasn't supposed to sleep in past noon, but long shifts are a killer, and Adora's too tired to care about schedules and routines and workouts anymore. Burnout will do that.

Glimmer, half-asleep on the couch, raises a hand in greeting when Adora comes in. Bow is out, judging by the silence. Adora grabs her laptop from the coffee table and slumps down next to her.

"You sleep well?"

Glimmer hums, tipping her head onto the arm of the couch. "Mhm."

That's a lie, and they both know it. No one's been sleeping well. There's a weird anxious energy that always starts dripping out of the cracks in the walls and feeling its way under their skin around the run up to Christmas. Glimmer and Bow hung lights around the windows and doors to try to keep it at bay this year, but the effect didn't last. Adora thinks it has something to do with her.

"Looking forward to going home?" Glimmer asks, so quietly Adora barely hears it.

She can't help the smile that turns up the corners of her mouth. "Yeah. Always."

Glimmer grins back, looking a little more alive. “You guys are so cute. Don’t tell Catra I said that.”

“She’ll probably kill you,” Adora agrees. The mental image of Catra, scowling and huffing *I’m not cute* and scrunching up her nose in the way she does when she’s only pretending to be pissed, makes her heart do something funny and lovesick in her chest.

G-d , she misses her.

Glimmer lets her have another minute of staring wistfully into space before she pokes her with her foot. “Have you thought about moving all your stuff back yet?”

“Damn, you really must want to get rid of me,” Adora teases. Glimmer shoves her.

“No, you loser. I’m just wondering.”

She shrugs. Honestly, she hadn’t really given much thought to it. Which is bad, and she probably should have at least *considered* how she was going to transport three years’ worth of clutter halfway across the country before she handed in her two weeks notice and dropped out of school, but — well —

"I'll talk about it with Catra," she says, because she needs to say *something* . Glimmer rolls her eyes fondly. "I was thinking of asking you guys for some help, though."

"You're a terrible liar, you know."

Adora sighs. "I know."

Day 3 - December 23rd, 8:31 AM

The kitchen is also cold.

Adora gets up earlier than Catra, especially on the weekends. She never gets used to how quiet it is without her, how cold the floor gets when no-one's there to dance around on them like an idiot at an unreasonable hour in the morning.

Melog sits semi-patiently at her feet and watches her make the darkest coffee possible with a vaguely disappointed expression. She ignores the disapproval. It's going to be a long day, and she needs everything can get to keep her sanity in check.

And then her phone buzzes, and it's like sunlight has poured in through the blinds and lit the world in shining red-and-gold. Catra

scrambles to pick it up and nearly drops her cup in the process.

princess (affectionate) (dumbass) *at* ***8:46 AM***

Hey Catra?

Can we call?

Catra's heart drops in her chest. Adora only asks her to call if it's urgent, and it's the middle of the night where she is — she must be either really drunk or really upset, and Catra doesn't know which one she'd prefer.

what did you do

who do i need to kill

Nothing!!! Don't worry!!!
I'm fine

Really

I just need to hear your voice

You know?

yeah

seriously though if you need anything

i'm always here

I know <33

Are you free now?

mhm

scorp is coming over a little later though

about midday

plus you should probably sleep lmao

>:(

Okay finee

I'll call you when I wake up

good

get some sleep princess

i'll be here when you wake up

<33

<333

It really is getting properly light outside, now. Light is starting to filter in through the blinds in the way it usually does in the autumn. Catra isn't complaining.

She stares at the phone in her hands for a second and puts it down on the counter. Adora will text her when she's awake. Adora will be smiling into her phone and talking gently into her ear from the other side of the country in a few hours. Adora will be home soon.

“I love you,” she says into the silence. No one answers. She doesn’t need them to.

Day 4 - December 24th, 00:12 AM

Adora doesn’t get the chance to call until just past midnight in Catra’s timezone. When she answers the phone, her voice is quiet and slurred and heavy with sleep, and Adora can’t stop herself from giggling like a little kid and asking “Tired, baby?” in the way that Catra pretends to hate.

“Mmf. No. Shut up,” Catra mumbles. Adora melts into her seat. “What did you want to talk about?”

She bites her lip to keep herself from smiling. Catra can always tell when she’s smiling, and then she’ll press her until Adora tells her about the job and the move and college, and she’s always been a terrible liar. “Nothing. Really. I just — I miss you.”

“You’re a terrible liar,” Catra says automatically, huffing as she rolls onto her front. Fabric shifts right into the microphone. Bow pauses skimming through a Physics book and looks up from the kitchen table to grin at her. Adora makes a face right back.

"I'm a great liar. I'll tell you all about it when I get home. I promise."

Catra groans. "Adora."

"Nope. It's a surprise. A Christmas surprise."

" *G-d* . Okay, fine. You're impossible."

"You love it," Adora grins. She can picture the face Catra is making right now, so vividly it aches.

Catra sighs, shifting around in her bed again. "I do."

Catra <3 <3 <3 at 4:29 PM

i really need to teach you how to use the timezone widget babe

Hehehe

Late-night calls are romantic!!

sure

letting your girlfriend sleep is also romantic

But then we wouldn't fall asleep on call together!!

That's romantic!!

yeah okay it is

still

i'm convinced you never sleep

Something like that LOL

babe

sweetheart

love of my life

you're insane

i'm not letting you leave the house until you develop a normal sleep schedule

Awww I love you too

Almost done with packing!!

I'll be on the plane soon

Happy Christmas Eve btw <333

Wait do people wish each other happy Christmas Eves

perfect that means i have just enough time to turn the house into a dreidel death trap

uhh idk?

i assume so

i don't know what normal people do

happy erev christmas i guess

LMAO

Happy erev christmas <3

Chag Christmas sameach??

Idk

we're so good at this

Day 5 - December 25th, 11:39 AM

Catra can't sit still.

She woke up abnormally early yesterday to hang up the lights she took down for Chanukah, narrowly avoided accidentally strangling Melog with tinsel, hung (fake) mistletoe in all the doorways because she's a lovesick idiot — and still, *still* she's convinced there's something left to do.

It's not like she *had* to do any of it, she just wants the house to look. Nice. For Adora, who loves the lights and the tinsel and the mistletoe, who loves the soft music that filters in from the upstairs apartment every day in December without fail, who looks at her like she is something magical, something worth loving. She doesn't really do Christmas, but Adora — Adora does, and Catra loves Adora, loves Adora's smile and bubbling laugh and awkward hands and —

Christ.

Well, yes, that's sort of the whole point.

She texts Adora once, briefly — *merry christmas starlight. i love you* — and then switches her phone off and resists the urge to launch it across the room. Melog pads around her feet as she stands in the middle of the living room and tries to find something to do with all this nervous energy.

She doesn't have to wait long.

The cab pulls up outside their apartment block at 11:42 AM exactly. Catra, who has been anxiously watching cars arrive and depart from the window for about an hour now, watches Adora smile as she climbs out of her seat and feels like her heart is about to fall out of her chest.

She doesn't know what to do, so she stands awkwardly by the door and waits. Melog threads around her feet and begs her for food, but she doesn't move, *can't* move —

A key turns in the lock. Catra forgets to breathe.

The room explodes into light when Adora opens the door.

They stare at each other for a moment. Catra breathes through the urge to cry. Adora is *here* , standing in the doorway, wearing those ridiculous old glasses with the thick grey frames she only uses when she's tired and clutching at the bag slipping off her shoulder and gazing at her with gentle blue eyes and, *oh* —

"Hi," Adora says breathlessly.

Catra pulls her into a hug before she can get another word in. Adora drops her bag and wraps her arms around her shoulders the same way she has a million times before, laughing. The sound is dizzying. "I missed you too, baby."

There's something in the air this time, something buzzing and electric and different from before. It hits Catra the moment they touch. She tucks her head under Adora's chin and sucks in a long breath that definitely doesn't tremble a little bit, lets herself drown in the *feeling* of her, mumbles "I love you," into the fabric of her jacket. Adora grins and presses a kiss to the top of her head. She doesn't need to say it back.

They hold each other like that for a while. Catra sucks in shuddering breaths, and Adora kisses the top of her head in a way that says *I know, I know, I love you, I know* .

"I missed you so much," she says hoarsely, burying her face in Adora's neck. She smells like sandalwood and pine needles and rusty metal and it's so awfully, stingingly familiar that she has to swallow the choked noise trying to make its way out of her throat. Again.

Adora hums. She doesn't need to say anything now, either — Catra feels it in the way her arms tighten around her, in the ragged breaths she takes in as she lets her head drop to Catra's shoulder, in the way her hands flex against the small of her back. Catra kisses what she can reach of her jaw for the first time in months and she squeaks adorably, and Melog butts his head into her calf in greeting and she jumps away to grab him before he can escape.

The lovestruck look Adora gives her as she steps back makes Catra want to cry a little bit.

They're still standing in the doorway. Adora's bag is resting against the frame, which the more sane and rational part of her that hasn't yet dissolved into incoherency thinks is pretty unsafe. The rest of her bags are lying awkwardly in the hallway — she must have dropped everything halfway to the door. Which is sweet. And a little dumb.

"Adora?"

Adora kisses Melog on the head, too, and lets him go. He springs off towards the kitchen to wait for food. "Yeah?"

Catra opens her mouth to say something about bringing her bags inside and forgets it instantly. *G-d, I'm losing my mind.* She points up to the door and the (fake) mistletoe hanging above their heads instead, because she's going insane and her thoughts have

disintegrated into nothing and Adora's eyes are soft as she pulls her in and kisses her like it's the end of the world.

"You said you had a surprise," she says, much later, running her fingers through Adora's hair as they lie side by side along the couch and listen to the shitty Christmas music blasting from the apartment above. "You kept teasing me about it. Do I finally get to know what it is?"

Adora hums. She's been doing a lot of that recently. "Oh, that. Yeah, I dropped out of school."

" *What?* "

She grins lazily, leaning into Catra's hand as it stills against her temple. "Yeah. And I handed in my two weeks. So, uh, surprise! I'm staying home forever!"

"What the fuck, baby?" Catra says weakly. "What the *fuck* ?"

Adora's smile falters, just barely, and she feels it like a knife to the stomach. "Did you not —"

“No,” she gets out, “no, I just — if you dropped out of the school of your dreams literally because I’m a loser who can’t live on my own then I —”

“I dropped out because I fucking hate it there,” Adora says, and the blinding smile is back, sending Catra’s heart pinging around her ribcage for something like the fifth time in the space of an hour. “Maybe in a few years I could try again, but I can’t do it without you. I don’t *want* to do it without you. But if you don’t think that was the right decision we can —”

“We don’t need to talk about it,” Catra cuts her off, pressing a kiss to the corner of her mouth. They haven’t done this in so long that it shuts Adora up entirely. She blushes like she always does, turning her head down and away and scrunching her nose up and — *focus, Catra* . “I just wish you *told* me.”

“We both know that would have made waiting worse,” Adora says, still blushing.

She’s right. Catra hates it when she’s right.

“What about your roommates?”

“Bow offered to drive the rest of my stuff up in the new year,” she grins. “He’s coming up to visit for his brother’s birthday anyway.

“Wait, so, the 14th —”

“Originally I was going to just go back and forth myself,” Adora explains. Somehow tinsel has gotten tangled in her hair, and it catches the light of the decorations and makes her eyes look almost silver.

“So you had a whole plan,” Catra says, the weight of it having chosen that moment to hit her. “You — you quit your *job* and you quit fucking culinary school and you’re moving halfway across the country so you — *Jesus* , Adora —”

“The stress was too much.” She says it so casually, rolling onto her side and resting her head on Catra’s collarbone. “I couldn’t handle going back. And working a shitty job at the same time. And missing you. And dealing with, you know, therapy and meds and stuff. But I think — even without the stress, I couldn’t stand missing you, you know? I hate being away from you and knowing just how much you’re hating it too.”

Catra squeezes her eyes shut and lets it sink in. Adora is coming home. Adora is here, now, and she’s not leaving again. Adora is *staying* . Adora is prioritising her fucking *mental health* for once in her life. Adora, who is gentle and warm and who loves like the sun, would turn around her whole life in an instant to be with Catra.

“Are you mad at me?”

“What? No, of course not. I’m —” she takes another breath, curling her fingers into Adora’s hair. “You have no idea how much I missed you.”

The light from the decorations dances underneath her eyelids, red and blue and green, back and forth until she’s dizzy with it. Adora smiles against her collarbone, slotting into place against her like she’d never left. “I think I do.”

They fall asleep like that, tangled up together on the couch in the living room in their tiny shitty apartment. It’s nice, Catra thinks, not to have the thought of sleeping alone again in the new year burning a hole in the back of her mind. It’s nice — more than nice — to have Adora, stupid goofy wonderful Adora, dozing off in her arms like this, mumbling soft *I love you* s into her neck.

When she wakes up, Adora is still asleep, and her phone is lighting up with notifications. Catra reaches over to grab it, intending to scroll aimlessly through her messages until Adora wakes up, and stops short.

princess (affectionate) (dumbass) *at* ***9:02 PM***

Goodnight <3

gn princess <333

merry christmas starlight. i love you

princess (affectionate) (dumbass) at 7:56 AM

I'm omw!! Getting in the taxi now!!!

Merry Christmas baby <3 I love you and I can't wait to spend the rest of my life with you

You mean the world to me <333

I'm getting sappy now aaaahhh

This is what you're like every time I leave you alone for

more than a day

You turn into a ridiculous goopy mess

It's so cute

You're so cute and so pretty and I love you

I'm so happy I get to spend Christmas with you

We can make up for all the Chanukahs we spent apart

I'm losing my mind a little bit

I think I might potentially be a little bit sleep deprived

I know you won't answer because you probably can't bear to look at your phone right now but if you see this I'm going to nap now <333 I can't wait to see you baby

I love you more than anything

Merry christmas

Catra grins at her phone. She's right; the past few days have turned her into even more of a pining mess than usual. Adora makes her feel capable of loving, of gentleness, in ways she never thought she could be, and — *I'm doing it again* .

"Look what you've done to me," she says softly. Adora smiles in her sleep. She's always smiling — sunshine in human form, and so on. Part of her wonders how her face doesn't hurt all the time. Catra never wants her to stop.

you're right

i love you so much

you turn me into mush you dork

you're ruining my extremely rad and cool image

i hope you know that you were worth it

all the long distance stuff

all of it

you're always worth it

i know that you don't think you are

but you're worth it

see what you've turned me into?

when you wake up and read this you're going to think i'm insane lol

did you know you smile in your sleep when i talk to you?

i love you

She falls back asleep quickly after that. The Christmas music from the apartment above keeps playing late into the night.

End Notes

:D

that was the cut down section of the ending btw. like i had to spend a day cutting stuff out. the final doc was 17 pages (most of which was nonsense) and i cut it down to 13. i would have kept it in and filled out the fic a little more if it actually. you know. made sense HFDJFD

if you liked the fic, spotted any glaring errors, or hate my guts because of the sheer amount of run-on sentences i make you read with everything i post, please leave a kudos/comment!! my tumblr is @nonbinarychaoticstupid if you want to catch me there! i'm currently going insane about wednesday! it's a fun time!

also please check out the other works in this collection if you have the time and take a look at the upcoming spop futures zine (@SpopFuturesZine on twitter) because i wrote something for that and i'm really genuinely proud of it fjhkdfhkhsj

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!